

Bombers' return to US is minimal constraint on Iran escalation

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State and local governments will drive policy on AI-driven surveillance

Bombers' return to US is minimal constraint on Iran escalation. The US Air Force recalled its B-1 Lancer bomber aircraft from RAF Fairford in the UK over the weekend. The withdrawal was reportedly linked to a foiled Iran-backed terror plot targeting the base.

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The B-1s' return to the US is a minimal constraint on US power projection in the Middle East and does not seriously reduce President Donald Trump's escalatory options as the midterm elections approach. The US operational bomber arsenal has the necessary range and aerial refueling capabilities to strike the Middle East from domestic bases and has done so under Presidents Trump and Joe Biden.

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While unusual, the decision to move the bombers back to the US rather than to other bases in the region reflects the politically contentious nature of basing in the UK—which caused opposition that previously prevented and then limited strikes out of Fairford—as well as the vulnerability of forward bases in the conflict with Iran.

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At the height of Operation Epic Fury, the US had six B-52 and 18 B-1 bombers stationed at RAF Fairford. As US-Iran peace talks began in Doha in July the B-52 contingent returned home, with the B-1s remaining to support operations in the Middle East from the base. The principal tradeoffs caused by flying from the US instead of the UK would be flight time and the need for aerial refueling capabilities.

Times/Siena poll keeps Democrats buoyant in the key states. The marquee New York Times/Siena College poll—with an A grade in Nate Silver's pollster ratings—came out over the weekend, showing Democrats up in Texas, Alaska, and Ohio, down by only one in Iowa, and tied in Kansas.

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A previous iteration of the poll showed Democrats up in Michigan and down in Maine, meaning that, by Times/Siena's lights, Democrats are on track for a 51-seat majority (with North Carolina the fourth flip). That reaffirms our view that Maine is no longer must-win state for Democrats, who are polling well enough elsewhere (see US Daily: "Maine is no longer a must-win for Democrats ," 30 September 2026).

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The most notable result from the poll is that the Kansas race is tied--the Texas, Alaska, and Ohio numbers are in step with polling averages. Kansas has been sparsely polled, leading many to doubt that Democrats truly stood a fighting chance; the tied result from a high-quality pollster is the strongest indication yet that this is a race taking seriously—and that Democrats have meaningfully expanded the map into red states.

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Still, there's reason not to see Democrats as too strong of favorites. Democrats still don't have much room to maneuver, with polling misses against them in any of the competitive states enough to let Republicans hang on. And, though the Times/Siena pairing does have a strong track record, it hasn't been immune from big misses in the past (such as Nevada and Pennsylvania in 2024). While this is clearly a good piece of news for Democrats, we think the Senate outlook remains close, with Democrats 55% favorites to flip the chamber (see Democrats are now narrow Senate favorites , 24 September 2026).

State and local governments will drive policy on AI-driven surveillance. Congressional progressives released a bill that would block the use of Flock cameras and other automatic license plate readers at the federal level and end federal funding from state and local governments that use such cameras.

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This is the first real federal instantiation of what has become a firestorm over the use of Flock cameras, which track and record the locations of vehicles, at the state and local level in recent months. Amid a massive local backlash, dozens of municipalities have moved to cancel municipal contracts with Flock or have suspended the use of their cameras pending reviews. Those pressures will feed through to federal elected officials, and members of both parties will likely feel strong pressures from local constituents to take a stance on the Flock bill, even if it faces only remote odds of passing.

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The scale of the backlash is a good indication of the state of public reaction to AI and concerns over data privacy. While the public broadly speaking views AI apps positively—an Argument poll from June found 38% of respondents favorable to ChatGPT, against 27% unfavorable—those attitudes turn negative when it comes to the physical imprints of AI: data centers and Flock cameras, where the personal benefits are harder to see.

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A divided government after the midterms means that local and especially state governments will continue to drive policy on the adoption of AI-driven surveillance technology; given the scale of the backlash, and the responsiveness of mayors and governors to small but concentrated pressure groups, more restrictions are likely in 2027.

Quote of the Day

"We believe that the world should accept some bad things happening for the benefits of this technology and people having the agency." - OpenAI CEO Sam Altman speaking to Politico about how his company differs from Anthropic; while AI developers have started endorsing proposed limits on the technology

and attempting to address public distrust of it, their rhetoric has so far done little to address concerns about AI's dangerous impacts.

On the Radar

12-18 October: IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

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